Edexcel Specification: c1250–c1500

- **1. Causes of disease:** Supernatural/religious explanations, Astrology, Four Humours, and Miasma.
- **2. Prevention and treatment:** Religious actions, bloodletting, purging, purifying air.
- **3. Medical care:** The role of physicians, apothecaries, barber surgeons, and hospitals.
- **4. Case Study: The Black Death (1348):** Beliefs about its causes, treatments, and prevention.

MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

RENAISSANCE

Paper 1: Medicine Through Time with the Western Front

Scholar: ______________________

Class: ______________________

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _________

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale

Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?			
L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?			
L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?

(See Textbook Page 3)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how Thomas Sydenham's scientific approach to observation changed the diagnosis of disease.
- ☐ Assess the role of the printing press and the Royal Society in communicating and spreading scientific ideas.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

Who were the 'flagellants'?

State one common medieval preventative measure for the Black Death.

What was the Renaissance?

What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

Who was Thomas Sydenham?

How did medieval hospitals differ from modern ones?

What was the purpose of 'bleeding' (phlebotomy) in medieval medicine?

Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

What was the Royal Society?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Humanism | **Nullius in Verba** | **Animalcules**

During the Medical Renaissance, a cultural shift known as [. . . . .] encouraged doctors and scientists to think for themselves, question ancient texts, and verify claims through empirical observation. This hands-on mindset was championed by the Royal Society, whose strict motto [. . . . .] drove researchers to reject traditional theories in favor of rigorous experimentation. Although new scientific instruments like advanced microscopes allowed pioneers to observe microscopic [. . . . .] for the very first time, these discoveries had little immediate impact on treating patients because there was no proof that these tiny organisms actually caused illness.

Q1. Identify one invention that helped spread new ideas during the Renaissance.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q2)

How did Sydenham's belief that diseases were like plants or animals challenge the traditional Theory of the Four Humours?

- [ ] A. It proved that diseases were caused by invisible germs.
- [ ] B. It meant diseases were separate entities with specific symptoms, rather than a personal imbalance of a patient's humours.
- [ ] C. It showed that diseases could only be cured by herbal remedies.
- [ ] D. It proved that diseases were a punishment from God.

Q3. Describe what Vesalius discovered about Galen.

Q4. Explain the purpose of the Royal Society.

Q5. Evaluate the extent to which the Renaissance changed beliefs about the causes of illness.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, was the work of individual physicians like Thomas Sydenham more important in challenging traditional medical beliefs than institutional developments like the founding of the Royal Society?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Sydenham's Observationes Medicae classifying diseases like scarlet fever vs. the Royal Society publishing Leeuwenhoek's discoveries in Philosophical Transactions).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Pace of Change in Renaissance Medicine

Historians often debate the extent to which the Renaissance c1500-c1700 represented a genuine breakthrough or a period of stagnation in the understanding of disease causes. Traditional historians emphasize a 'Scientific Revolution,' pointing to the works of Vesalius, Harvey, and Leeuwenhoek as a rapid and complete dismantling of medieval Galenism. However, revisionist historians argue that this period was actually characterized by overwhelming continuity for the average patient. They argue that while elite physicians in organizations like the Royal Society debated new ideas, daily treatments (such as bleeding and purging to balance the humours) remained completely unchanged. Because there was *no scientific proof that Leeuwenhoek's 'animalcules' actually caused disease, everyday medical practice clung tightly to the Theory of the Four Humours and miasma for centuries after the Renaissance.*

General Notes

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500-c1700.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q9. Explain one way in which knowledge of human anatomy in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700) was different from knowledge of human anatomy in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q10. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500-c1700.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The printing press
- The Royal Society

You must also use information of your own.

L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?

(See Textbook Page 6)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Analyze the continuities and changes in Renaissance treatments and preventions, including the impact of exploration and alchemy.
- [ ] Explain how institutional changes, specifically the Dissolution of the Monasteries, altered hospital care in England.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What was the Renaissance?

What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

Who was Thomas Sydenham?

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

What was 'transference'?

In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

Explain the role of the apothecary in medieval medicine.

Why did Vesalius' anatomical discoveries have limited immediate impact on medical treatments?

Name one new herbal remedy brought to Europe from the New World.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Transference | Iatrochemistry | Dissolution of the Monasteries

Your Sentence:

Q1. Identify one new herbal remedy brought from the 'New World'.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q2)

Why was the importation of cinchona bark from South America a more successful treatment than traditional humoural methods?

☐ A. It contained quinine, which actually treated the specific symptoms of malaria, rather than just attempting to rebalance humours.

☐ B. It was a holy relic blessed by the Pope.

☐ C. It killed the germs that caused malaria.

☐ D. It was used to draw bad humours out of the skin.

Q3. Describe the approach of Thomas Sydenham.

Q4. Explain why treatments for ordinary people hardly changed during the Renaissance.

Q5. To what extent did the 'New World' improve medical treatments?

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, did the introduction of global herbal remedies and chemical cures represent a more significant improvement in treatment than the gradual reforms made to the training of physicians?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the successful use of cinchona bark for malaria versus the fact that physicians' training was still largely book-based with very little hands-on dissection experience).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Renaissance Progress: Breakthrough or Backstep?

Historians actively debate whether the Renaissance represented genuine progress in patient care or a period of regression. Traditionalist accounts often celebrated the 'rebirth' of medical science, highlighting how the shift towards chemical cures and Vesalian anatomy laid the foundations of modern clinical practice. However, revisionist social historians argue that for the average sick person, the Renaissance was actually a time of decline in care. They point out that Henry VIII's closure of the monasteries in 1536 destroyed the medieval hospital safety net, leaving thousands of poor patients without any institutional care. Furthermore, they highlight that some new treatments, such as using highly toxic mercury to treat syphilis or smoking tobacco as a 'cure-all' defense against plague, actually did far more physical harm than medieval herbal remedies ever did.

General Notes

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Explain why there was little change in medical treatments during the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700), despite new anatomical discoveries.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q9. Explain one way in which medical treatments in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700) were similar to medical treatments in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q10. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Andreas Vesalius
- The printing press

You must also use information of your own.

L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?

(See Textbook Page 10)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance of William Harvey's discovery and the reasons for its limited short-term impact.
- ☐ Compare the government and public responses to the 1665 Great Plague with the 1348 Black Death.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

What was 'transference'?

What did William Harvey discover about the human body?

What did Harvey prove wrong about Galen's theories of blood?

In what year did the Great Plague hit London?

How did local mayors try to prevent the spread of the Black Death in 1348?

What was the Theory of the Four Humours?

What was the 'Stagnation Paradox' regarding Harvey's discovery?

Explain one way the government response to the Great Plague (1665) was better than the Black Death (1348).

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: ***Circulation***

Q1. Identify what William Harvey proved about the blood.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q2)

What was the main reason why Harvey's discovery of blood circulation did not immediately change medical treatments?

☐ A. Because he refused to publish his findings in a book.

☐ B. Because the Church banned his book and executed him.

☐ C. Because knowing how the blood circulated did not provide doctors with any new drugs or cures for sick patients.

☐ D. Because he still believed the liver manufactured blood.

Q3. Describe how Harvey proved Galen wrong.

Q4. Explain how the Great Plague of 1665 was dealt with differently from the Black Death.

Q5. Evaluate the short-term significance of Harvey's discovery.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Why was William Harvey's brilliant discovery of blood circulation completely ignored in the prevention and treatment of the Great Plague of 1665?

Think: Jot down your explanation and one piece of evidence (e.g., how knowing that blood flows did not help cure a disease when germs were still undiscovered, or how doctors did not believe Harvey because they felt it had no practical clinical application).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Significance of William Harvey

Historians often debate whether William Harvey represents a sudden turning point or a very gradual stepping stone in medicine. Traditionalist historians celebrate his work as a revolutionary breakthrough that demolished Galenic physiology. However, revisionist historians emphasize the extreme limits of his immediate significance. They point out that a lot of contemporary doctors simply ignored or openly criticized Harvey because his discovery offered no practical treatment for sick patients. As a result, English medical textbooks continued to print Galen's flawed theories until 1651, and Harvey's findings were not taught in universities until 1673, decades after his discovery.

General Notes

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. 'The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Explain why the government's response to the Great Plague of 1665 was more effective than its response to the Black Death of 1348.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q9. Explain one way in which the response to the Great Plague in London (1665) was different from the response to the Black Death (1348).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q10. 'The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Watchmen
- The animal cull

You must also use information of your own.

Factors Overview: Renaissance

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	